

Medieval secular architecture

Many new towns and cities were established in Europe during the high and late middle ages; from the 12th century on, the spread of urbanization saw the construction of town halls, guilds and other mercantile and civic buildings. In Britain, new towns sprang up around castles; Edward I created settlements to pacify the recently conquered principality of Wales, such as in Caernarfon and Conwy. Across Europe, the establishment of building regulations led to new rules on the heights and shapes of buildings, the widths of streets, projections of roofs, plus waste management, drainage and fire regulations. At Siena in Italy, for example, official regulations governing the dimensions of the palaces facing the Piazza del Campo date from 1298. Other extant cities that adhered to such structural rules were in Belgium, where some of the finest Gothic architecture appeared in town halls. Spain is home to some well-preserved Gothic castles; and in England, the university buildings of Oxford (opposite) and Cambridge are outstanding examples of Gothic civic architecture.

